

Changing world-view

Google gave away a whole-Earth catalog inspired designer patch to all TEDsters



TED talks to Digit

To get a closer feel of TED, read our discussion with Lakshmi Pratury, co-host TEDIndia 2009

When asked about his favourite TED videos, Chris Anderson recommends Dan Gilbert, a Harvard psychologist's talk on happiness that suggests "We synthesise happiness, but we believe happiness is a thing to be found." This revelatory piece of pop psychology goes on to explain that choice is an enemy to our innate sense of happiness, and that our psychological immune system works best when we are trapped. "We are really bad at knowing what will make us happy," he said.

The event granted free entry to 103 TED Fellows - young visionaries born or working in South Asia to even out the demographics a bit, which usually veered towards "fat, white, North American and over 40," quipped Tom Reilly, the Fellows Director. TEDIndia Fellows are, according to web site, "A diverse group of men and women... Engineers, environmental scientists and pollution experts, human-rights activists, musicians, athletes and filmmakers."

One jolly-good fellow, Gyanesh Pandey had left his cushy job in the semiconductor industry in LA, to electrify 5,000 households in 30 villages in his native Bihar, using rice husk, an agricultural waste. Viraj Puri, CEO of Gotham Greens is creating rooftop farms in New York. MIT Alumni Kamal Qadir, CEO of CellBazaar.com has introduced a mobile-phone based electronic marketplace in Bangladesh.



Shashi Tharoor, Minister of State for External Affairs was among the speakers to address the audience at TEDIndia 2009



Pop singer Usha Uthup entertained the audience after the daily sessions

"We come from a land of insight, intelligence and spirituality. It would be a tragedy to lose an entire generation to the goal of financial success," said Lakshmi Pratury, who co-hosted the event with Anderson.

Pratury said she's optimistic about the prospects of Indian youth, and that we need to encourage their spirit of creativity and innovation. "We need to push our kids into economically sustainable fields; we need writers, journalists, artists too. We need to let our children figure out what they're good at, and create professions that suit them."

TED has diverged from its core fundamentals of Technology, Entertainment and Design, its scope has grown wider, and is now a culture-jamming network for artists, free culture activists, social entrepreneurs and self-improvement gurus like Anthony Robbins and Sad-guru Jaggi Vasudev. What is technology, anyway? Is it just silicon chips and software? One could argue that yoga is an open source technology for self-optimisation. An TED talk by Noah Feldman reflects on how both politics and religion are technological frameworks.

However, there was plenty of core technology on offer, not just from the speakers but also from the 103 fellows, and the 800-strong audience. Here are some of the trends - ideas that came from

India and could some day shape the rest of the world.

Technology

MIT whiz-kid Pranav Mistry, and digital-historian Ramchandra Budihaal, dazzled the audience with a cypherpunk vision of future, augmenting reality using hardware that was cheaper than an Apple iPod Touch (less than \$300). While Pranav Mistry's SixthSense interface uses a pocket projector, a mirror and a camera, Budihaal's E3iT system uses a head-mounted camera and goggles.

Going solo in his latest demonstration, he explained how he used the scroll wheels from a ball mouse to create an interactive 3D claw-hand user interface for just two dollars; less than a hundred rupees. "This is what we learnt from India, there is a lot of energy in the scene. I was more excited about taking the technology to the masses." Pranav told Anderson in a post-demo discussion, where he famously declared that he would go open source with his software in a month.

A Nokia employee who spoke to us later that day said he wasn't convinced if SixthSense going open source would have a disruptive influence to the world of consumer electronics. Given the variables and the monopolised tech landscape